TRANSITIONING TO BEING A SUPERVISOR

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Transitioning to Supervisor Video • Transitioning and New Leaders Guide to The First 60 Days Article • Building a Support Network and Finding a Mentor Article
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Explain the challenges and expectations associated with transitioning from peer to supervisor, including shifts in responsibility, communication, and power dynamics, in order to establish professional credibility and confidence early in their role. • Apply key strategies from the First 60 Days framework—such as setting expectations, establishing one-on-ones, observing team dynamics, and communicating effectively—to create a strong foundation for team leadership and trust. • Evaluate their current support system and identify specific internal and external relationships (e.g., HR, peers, mentors) that can provide guidance, reduce isolation, and accelerate their supervisory development. • Develop a personal leadership action plan that includes building a peer network, finding a mentor, setting early team priorities, and implementing quick wins—aligning their efforts with organizational goals and team needs.
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 180 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

Stepping into a supervisory role marks a significant and often complex transition in a professional's career. New supervisors must quickly shift from being individual contributors to becoming team leaders responsible for guiding others, making decisions, and upholding

organizational standards. This change can be both exciting and overwhelming, especially when navigating former peer relationships, increased accountability, and new performance expectations. Addressing this transition directly—and early—is essential. With the right mindset and support, new supervisors can build confidence, earn credibility, and avoid common pitfalls that derail early success. Helping them understand the dynamics of power, communication, and responsibility sets the stage for stronger leadership and healthier teams.

Getting off to a strong start requires more than enthusiasm—it requires intention. Best practices such as setting clear expectations, observing team dynamics, and establishing consistent communication routines help supervisors establish a solid foundation during their first few months. Just as critical is building a support network. New leaders benefit tremendously from connecting with peers in similar roles and seeking out a mentor who can offer guidance and serve as a sounding board. Proactively tapping into these resources encourages ongoing learning, helps new supervisors manage challenges with greater ease, and accelerates their development into confident, capable leaders. Together, these strategies create a launchpad for long-term supervisory success.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This “pair and share” technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the “pair and share” method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then give those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the whole group.

Transitioning to Supervisor General Questions

The following questions are based on the video:

1. What has been the most surprising or challenging part of your transition from peer to supervisor so far? How have your relationships with former coworkers changed since

taking on this new role? What boundaries or communication habits could you put in place to maintain professionalism while still being approachable?

2. In your first few weeks as a supervisor, how have you approached setting expectations with your team? What conversations have you had (or still need to have) about roles, goals, or work standards? How might asking your team for their expectations of you build trust early on?
3. Think about a time recently when you felt tempted to step in and "just do it yourself" instead of delegating. What stopped you from handing the task off to someone else? How might delegating more strategically help both your team grow and you stay focused on higher-priority responsibilities?
4. Every team has small annoyances or inefficiencies—what's one "quick win" you've already achieved or could tackle soon? How did (or could) involving your team in solving that issue build your credibility and encourage collaboration? What other small changes could you implement this month to build momentum?
5. Conflict or performance issues can be uncomfortable to address. When was the last time you noticed an issue but hesitated to say something? What's your current comfort level with giving corrective feedback or mediating disagreement? What's one thing you could practice to build your confidence in handling tough conversations?
6. Leadership is a journey of continuous learning. What's one leadership skill you're eager to improve in the next few months? How will strengthening that skill make you more effective as a supervisor? What resources (e.g., mentors, HR, training programs) can you tap into to keep growing in your role?

Additional Activity on *Transitioning Into Supervisory Role*:

1. Self-Assessment: Begin the workshop by providing participants with the transitioning to supervisor self-assessment questionnaire provided. Encourage them to reflect on their current habits, strengths, and areas for improvement. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas such as understanding the role, policy, process, communication, delegation, accountability, addressing conflict and professional development.
2. Group Discussion: Facilitate a group discussion where participants share their self-assessment results and insights. Encourage open dialogue about common challenges and best practices in transitioning to the new role. The results are broken into two different sections: areas of biggest concern and overall rating/interpretation. Guide participants to identify common themes and patterns in their transitioning process. Finally, identify ways that can work on the biggest areas of need.

The First 60 Days Questions

The following questions are based on the *Transitioning and New Leaders Guide to The First 60 Days* Article:

1. When you think about your first few days in a leadership role, what message do you want to send to your team from the start? How can your Day 1 communication help reduce

anxiety and set a positive tone? What's one element you want to include in your first team email or meeting that reflects your leadership values?

2. How do you plan to balance listening and observing with the urge to jump in and make changes right away? What might you miss if you try to "fix" things too soon? How can taking time to understand team dynamics and informal leadership help you make better decisions later?
3. Building relationships early on is key—how comfortable do you feel setting up one-on-one meetings with your team in your first two weeks? What do you hope to learn from these initial conversations? How might your approach to one-on-ones differ depending on the personality or role of each team member?
4. When it comes to setting goals, how will you ensure they align with your team's capacity and the broader mission of the organization? What steps can you take to involve the team in identifying priorities and milestones? How might quick wins help build momentum while you work toward longer-term goals?
5. How do you plan to communicate updates, progress, and direction to your team over the first 60 days? What cadence (e.g., weekly updates, check-ins) would keep people informed without overwhelming them? How can transparency and regular updates build trust and alignment?
6. As you reflect on your growth during the first 60 days, what leadership habit or skill do you most want to strengthen moving forward? What feedback will you seek from your team to support that growth? How can you maintain momentum and continuously develop as a leader beyond the first two months?

Additional First 60 Days Activity:

Supervisor Sprint Simulation (Objective): Simulate the decision-making challenges of a new supervisor's first two weeks by having participants prioritize and explain their actions under pressure.

Materials:

• Pre-printed task cards (14) based on the First 60 Days plan (If the training happens at any point after the first 14 days, select a two-week period of time that works for the participants)
• Time limit cards (e.g., "3 days," "5 days")
• Team role scenario (optional, for context)

Step-by-Step:

- **Step 1 – Introduce the Challenge:**
  Let participants know they'll simulate their first 14 days in a new leadership role and must prioritize tasks from a provided list.
- **Step 2 – Task Card Sort:**
  In small groups, participants sort 14 task cards into three columns:
  Do in the first 3 days, *Do in the first week*, *Do by end of week 2*. They must agree on order and rationale.
- **Step 3 – Share Decisions:**
  Each group shares their top 3 "first 3 days" choices and explains their logic. Trainer asks:
  - What values drove your prioritization?

- What trade-offs did you have to make?
- **Step 4 – Curveball Scenario:**
  Give each group a challenge card (e.g., “A team member resigns,” “Your supervisor cancels your meeting,” “Conflict erupts during a team huddle”). Ask:
  - Which of your priorities would shift and why?
  - How would you communicate this to your team?
- **Step 5 – Debrief:**
  Discuss:
  - What surprised you about your decision-making process?
  - How can you stay grounded in core leadership practices when unexpected things arise?
  - What can you do to remain flexible but intentional during your first weeks?

Building a Support Network and Finding a Mentor Questions

The following questions are based on the Building a Support Network and Finding a Mentor Article:

1. As a new supervisor, how comfortable do you feel reaching out for help or support when you face a challenge? What internal or external barriers might make it hard to ask for help? How could building a support network early on make your transition feel less isolating?
2. Who in your current professional environment could be part of your support system as you step into leadership? How can you proactively strengthen those relationships in the next month? What specific situations might arise where you’d benefit from having those allies to turn to?
3. When you think about the idea of having a mentor, what qualities or experiences would you look for in the right person? How could a mentor help you grow in areas you’re uncertain about right now? What’s a respectful way you might initiate a conversation with someone you’d like to learn from?
4. Think about a time you’ve learned a valuable lesson from someone else’s mistake or story—how did that influence your own behavior or decision-making? How might you use a mentor’s past experience to navigate tricky leadership moments? What questions could you ask to get the most insight from your mentor’s hindsight?
5. Peer learning groups are an underused tool for new supervisors. Have you ever been part of a group where people shared tips or talked through challenges together? What value could a casual support circle of new leaders bring to your development? If you were to start one, who would you invite and how would you structure it?
6. In what ways could HR and your direct supervisor be part of your early leadership success? How often do you currently connect with them—and what types of conversations would be most helpful? What can you do to make those interactions more proactive and mutually beneficial?

Additional Building a Support Network and Finding a Mentor Activity:

<u>Support System Mapping (Objective):</u> Help participants quickly identify and assess current and potential members of their professional support network while encouraging peer learning and new connections.

1. **Materials:**
   • Support System Grid (with columns: *Name/Role*, *Relationship Type*, *How They Support Me*, *Next Step*) - *This is provided at the end of the facilitation guide*
   • Timer or bell
   • Pens
2. **Step-by-Step:**

- **Step 1 – Personal Mapping:**
  Participants individually fill out their *Support System Grid* with at least 5 names (e.g., peers, former managers, HR, cross-department contacts, potential mentors). For each, they note how that person currently supports them and what next step they could take (e.g., schedule coffee, ask a question, send a thank-you).
- **Step 2 – Speed Sharing:**
  Pair participants. In 2-minute rounds, each person shares one person from their grid and how they support their leadership growth. After 2 minutes, rotate partners. Aim for 3–4 rotations.
- **Step 3 – Debrief in Small Groups:**
  In groups of 3–4, discuss:
  • What themes did you notice across your connections?
  • Where do you want to strengthen or expand your network?
  • Did someone else's idea give you inspiration?
- **Step 4 – Personal Goal Setting:**
  Each participant writes down:
  1. One person they'll reconnect with this month
  2. One new person they'll introduce themselves to for support or mentorship

General Transitioning to Supervisor Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

A. Understanding Your New Role

1. I am confident in my ability to shift from peer to leader without compromising professionalism.
2. I understand how my responsibilities have changed now that I'm a supervisor.
3. I embrace being seen as a decision-maker, even when it involves making tough calls.
4. I know how to set appropriate boundaries while maintaining healthy relationships with my team.

B. Policy, Process, and Communication

1. I feel well-versed in company policies and procedures from a supervisor's perspective.
2. I communicate clearly and consistently with both my team and upper leadership.
3. I proactively share updates with my team and leadership to keep everyone aligned.
4. I've established open communication channels with my team that balance accessibility with boundaries.

C. Delegation, Accountability, and Expectations

1. I feel confident assigning tasks and responsibilities based on my team's strengths.
2. I set clear expectations and performance standards when delegating tasks.
3. I distinguish between responsibility (doing the task) and accountability (owning the outcome).
4. I follow up on delegated tasks with appropriate check-ins and feedback.

D. Conflict, Feedback, and Performance Management

1. I address performance concerns or team conflict directly and professionally.
2. I provide timely and constructive feedback to guide improvement and recognize wins.
3. I use performance standards and metrics to guide decision-making and accountability.
4. I know when to escalate serious concerns to HR and seek guidance appropriately.

E. Support, Development, and Self-Awareness

1. I actively seek mentorship or support from peers, HR, or more experienced leaders.
2. I am building or participating in a network of peers to share ideas and challenges.
3. I regularly reflect on my leadership growth and seek development opportunities.
4. I feel equipped to model the behavior, communication, and professionalism I expect from my team.

<u>Calculate each section score:</u>

A. Understanding Your New Role – Total Score: _____ (out of 20 points)

B. Policy, Process, and Communication – Total Score: _____ (out of 20 points)

C. Delegation, Accountability, and Expectations – Total Score: _____ (out of 20 points)

D. Conflict, Feedback, and Performance Management – Total Score: _____ (out of 20 points)

E. Support, Development, and Self-Awareness– Total Score: _____ (out of 20 points)

Overall Score on All Parts: _____

Interpretation:

85–100 points (Confident Supervisor): You have a strong understanding of your new leadership role and are actively applying best practices in supervision. You demonstrate confidence, clarity, and consistency in your approach. Continue building on your momentum and seek opportunities to mentor others or lead larger initiatives.

70–84 points (Developing Supervisor): You're off to a solid start as a new supervisor. You're applying many of the right strategies, but there are still areas to strengthen. Focus on refining specific skills like delegation, feedback, or boundary-setting to increase your effectiveness and confidence.

55–69 points (Emerging Supervisor): You're beginning to grasp the essentials of supervision but may be struggling in key areas such as communication, time management, or accountability. Review the statements where you scored lower and create a plan to develop those skills over the next few months.

40–54 points (Challenged Supervisor): Your transition into supervision may feel overwhelming or unclear. You might be facing difficulties with role clarity, delegation, or team management. Pay close attention to the areas with lower scores and consider seeking mentorship or additional training to support your growth.

Below 40 points (At-Risk Supervisor): You are likely feeling unsure or underprepared in your supervisory role. This is a critical time to seek support, resources, and guidance. Focus on foundational skills like setting expectations, building relationships, and learning company policies to gain stability and confidence as a new leader.

Support System Grid

	NAME OF PERSON:	NAME OF PERSON:	NAME OF PERSON:	NAME OF PERSON:
ROLE/POSITION: NOTE THEIR TITLE OR HOW THEY RELATE TO YOUR WORK.				
TYPE OF RELATIONSHIP: IDENTIFY IF THEY ARE A PEER, LEADER, HR CONTACT, POTENTIAL MENTOR, ETC.				
HOW THEY CURRENTLY SUPPORT ME: BE HONEST—DO THEY OFFER GUIDANCE, LISTEN, CHALLENGE YOU, ETC.?				
HOW I'D LIKE THEM TO SUPPORT ME: THINK ASPIRATIONALLY—DO YOU WANT THEM AS A MENTOR, A THOUGHT PARTNER, A RESOURCE FOR ADVICE?				
NEXT STEP TO STRENGTHEN THE CONNECTION: LIST A CLEAR ACTION (E.G., "SET UP A MEETING," "SEND THANK-YOU NOTE," "ASK FOR ADVICE ON DELEGATION").				